

Post formats and when each one wins

Week 2, Lecture 2 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- The single post: tight argument, one idea
- The thread: when sequence earns the click
- Quote posts and replies as first-class formats
- Images, screenshots, and the one-graph rule
- A format-fit decision framework

By the end of this lecture you can pick the right format for any idea and explain why the other formats would be weaker choices.

The single post

The single post is the atomic unit

- One idea, one argument, one payoff, all within 280 characters
- The discipline of the single post makes every other format stronger
- Bush and Cole (2022): "Test as single tweet first; expand only if engagement validates"
- Basilio (2023): Bush posts 8-10 single tweets weekly, then expands only the top 2

The single post is not a thread that ran out of space. It is a complete thought.

When single posts win

- The idea has one strong point and the evidence fits in two sentences
- The hook is the argument: what follows is just the proof
- You want reach: single posts get indexed and shared more easily than threads
- You are testing an idea before investing in a longer format

Single posts are where 75% of your reach comes from. Write them with the same care as threads.

Anatomy of a strong single post

[Hook, claim, contrast, number, story-open, or question]

[One or two sentences of support or evidence]

[Closing line: the sharpest restatement of the point]

Every sentence earns its place. If a sentence restates the one before it, cut it.

The thread

When a thread earns the click on "show more"

- A thread is justified when the idea has multiple distinct sub-points, each worth a full beat
- The lead-in tweet is still the hook: it must work as a standalone post
- Bush and Cole (2022): "Every single word in your lead-in tweet should help with one of these two goals, otherwise you should cut it." (Goals: headline + hook)
- If the lead-in does not stand alone, the thread does not earn its length

A thread is not a blog post cut into pieces. Each tweet in the thread should hold up alone.

Thread structure

Bush and Cole (2022) prescribe four parts:

1. **Lead-in tweet:** headline + hook. The only tweet non-followers see.
2. **Main points:** each tweet stands alone. One idea per tweet, 3-7 points.
3. **TL;DR recap:** a single summary tweet. Readers who skim straight to the bottom still get the value.
4. **CTA:** one specific ask. Not "follow me for more" but a concrete next action.

Lean writing: tweet to thread

- Start with a single tweet. If it gets strong engagement, expand it
- Bush and Cole (2022): "Notice how the first sentence, and each of the Main Points, is the exact same as the original tweet."
- The hook transfers unchanged. The main points come from unpacking what the single tweet implied
- Engagement on the single tweet is proof that the idea earns the longer investment

Do not write threads speculatively. Let the audience tell you which ideas deserve more space.

Quote posts and replies

Quote posts as a first-class format

- A quote post (QP) surfaces your take to the audience of the original post
- Three uses: amplify (agree and add), critique (disagree and explain), contextualize (add a frame the original lacked)
- The QP must add value, not just repeat the original with a "+1"
- Your commentary is the post; the quoted content is the evidence

QPs that criticize without substance damage your positioning. QPs that add genuine insight build it fast.

Replies as reach mechanics

- A well-placed reply on a large account's post can earn more impressions than a standalone post
- The reply must stand alone: assume most readers will not click through to the original
- Short replies ("great point!") add no value and disappear from most feeds
- A reply that teaches something earns followers; a reply that performs engagement earns nothing

Replies are the lowest-barrier format and the most underused one among new creators.

Images and the one-graph rule

The one-graph rule

- One visual communicates one point. No more.
- A chart with five takeaways teaches none of them
- A screenshot that proves a single claim is stronger than a polished infographic with three
- Welsh (2022): the above-the-fold constraint applies to visuals too, the image must communicate before the viewer reads any caption

If you cannot say what the image proves in one sentence, the image is doing too much.

What images do well

- Screenshots of real data (follower count at a date, engagement on a post) make abstract claims concrete
- A before/after pair can show transformation with no words
- A simple annotated chart, one line, one label, communicates faster than a paragraph
- Images break up text-heavy feeds and signal production value even when the content is simple

What images do poorly: replace an argument. An image plus a weak caption is weaker than a strong sentence alone.

Format-fit decision framework

Is the idea complete in 280 characters?

YES: single post

NO: does it have 3–7 distinct sub-points?

YES: thread

NO: are you reacting to another post?

YES: quote post or reply

NO: does a single visual prove the point?

YES: image post (with tight caption)

NO: rethink the idea, it may not be ready

Bush and Cole (2022): formats are not preferences. They are constraints that sharpen the idea.

Take-aways

1. Test every idea as a single post first. Expand only when engagement validates.
2. A thread earns its length only when each tweet stands alone.
3. Quote posts and replies are first-class formats with real reach mechanics, use them deliberately.
4. One visual, one point. The one-graph rule applies to screenshots and charts equally.
5. Format fit is a decision, not a default. Match the container to the idea.

"Notice how the first sentence, and each of the Main Points, is the exact same as the original tweet."

Dickie Bush and Nicolas Cole, *Lean Writing on Twitter* (2022)

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Hook lab. Twenty hooks, one source claim, peer rating.
- **Reading:** Week 2 reading, Hooks and formats at </c/grow-on-x-26au/readings/wk02>
- **HW1 (Niche and bio):** due this week
- **HW2 (Twenty posts in seven days):** now out, use the formats from today